In the debt of care after Asia America

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Why do we care? $1.99

Can mutual aid ever be real? $2.99

David Graeber, debt, and moral obligation $3.99

An interlude in Asia America $5.99

Identification in Disidentification $7.99

My debt $8.88

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Why do we care? $1.99

Humans are socialized to care, or at the very least benefit from appearing to be. The kind of caring for/with/about those we have a direct relationship with seems easier to explain and understand. What I think is interesting is the care we perform for those that we aren't directly connected to: someone famous, a "national treasure", or something more trite, like, general animal welfare. Spending a little time online might make one believe that we really are one human race via the often sweet but mostly superficial connections we make across the internet. I like remembering how disconnected and different we actually are, yet manage to rally together in random, spontaneous moments.

I'm starting here, from the most basic social unit, care, when trying to answer the bigger question posed by this issue.

"How can we instill in our communities a sense of love and obligation for oppressed peoples who do not share their national origins or cultural traditions, and who do not speak their same language or practice their same religions and belief systems? How can we combat uncritical ethnic or racial loyalty, which encourages our people to identify with their own oppressors rather than the oppressed masses?"

Care mostly rests on some identification of commonality. And more often than not, that is understood by the crude signifier of Identity, as in, what you are and what you are not. The answer of how we can combat uncritical ethnic or racial loyalty, I think, lies in understanding what it is exactly that moves us to care about those that we aren't so similar to.

Can mutual aid ever be real? $2.99

Let's take mutual aid, for example. This practice is commonly explained by the mantra of "Solidarity, not Charity" — where a group shares resources. These acts of sharing are

multi-directional, self-directed and non-transactional — you give without the expectation of getting something back, and you ask and shall receive when you need help yourself. By definition, mutual aid is care that is supposed to be reciprocal, regardless of who is getting what. Those receiving and those giving regularly alternate. Mutual aid projects can be a way to understand how to create sustained relationships of care.

I have been fairly involved in several of these projects. Based solely on my experiences, I would argue that many mutual aid projects are dressed up one-way relationships. There are fixed 'givers' and 'receivers', with no symbiotic relationship between the former and the latter. Often 'givers' are: white, highly educated, transplants — people with "more". They interact with 'receivers' in discrete and planned environments, outside of daily life. Mutual aid is something you "sign up" for. You go in, hand out some apples, and go back to brunch. Life goes on.

I'm being a little harsh. I don't mean to only shit on my former co-organizers. The intention is there, and breaking away from traditional models of charity that we are taught from childhood takes time. Mutual aid is the entry point into caring a little more. There are groups - in the present moment, and historically - that make it work. The community forms and reforms around its members, organically and honestly. But these projects seem to struggle with much of the same dynamics, whether from the outset or eventually. The same misconceptions about the sustainability of mutual aid, questions about values, persistent conflict, misunderstanding, and the challenge of staying honest in a dishonest and harsh world. Why? Are do-gooders fixed in a saviorism dynamic? Are populations changing too fast for "community" to persist? Can we say for certain that real, identity agnostic care still exists?

David Graeber, debt, and moral obligation $3.99

I'm mostly being provocative, but I think some of the same

questions lie at the heart of why we struggle to build sustained relationships with those that aren't like us. I'll be explicit here — most people generally only care about things within their own lived experience. Or at least, it's much easier to. Looking at our histories, we see that mutual aid is just a thing that people who lived together automatically did. Some of the oldest solidarity practices emerged out of homogenous communities. Members of rotating savings pots, like su-su (indigenous to the many communities of West Africa), know each other. Lineage associations, such as the Man Clansmen Association at 4 Romilly Street in London, provide support and social services to people with the surname Man, who come from the same ancestral village in the New Territories, HK.

David Graeber describes these dynamics as part of the human economy — where exchange, and the trust required for it, happens all the time between people who know each other. They share a common context, and so it isn't necessary to quantify and tabulate things given or received — you give because of some inherited moral obligation from your parents telling you to be nice to others, because you know you will eventually come back to you. You will in return, receive at an indeterminate point by building care. Since then, the violent decontextualization of people through war, conquest, and the development of nation-states breaks these relationships of care. Interactions become impersonal, mediated through middlemen and institutions, and trust is not a given. Thus arises our modern bondage of debt: punishable if unpaid. We have lost our sense of moral indebtedness to one another. Some of this is because of impracticality — the world is simply too large. But within the increasingly heterogeneous environments of cities, we are often found with those alike.
An interlude in Asia America $5.99

It's been a funny experience, cosplaying as an Asian American. I'm assumed to be one, but don't identify with this label, because I'm not. I was born and grew up in Hong Kong,

where the past three generations of my family were also born. The promise of the British education system as a shortcut for social mobility meant I was sent to spend my teens and early twenties in and around London, England. America only comes into play in my adulthood. I moved to New York eventually to follow love, without knowing that my American lineage began with the patriarch of my grandfather's family, three generations prior, in the early twentieth century.

So while I could take on the label, I don't really. This is important to note because of my position as someone that hasn't ever felt an attachment to this label. My time in the United of Kingdom was spent looking longingly at the United of States. The Bay Area Asian — which included my maternal cousins — was an aspirational label. Through a romanticized, grass-is-greener lens, I wanted to be in Asia America so bad. Histories of institutional exclusion and myths of an American Dream seemed to have created an identity that appeared more clarified, accepted, and distinct, in comparison to the unfortunate moniker of the British Born Chinese (BBC - notably the same acronym for our public broadcaster. What a way to make a group sound adjacent to power). I like to say I am one of the first in the diaspora of Asia America. Double diaspora. Against the backdrop of a 0.8% Chinese population in the UK, a colonial history, and the stereotype of BBCs as apathetic, politically disengaged, and self-interested, I saw Asian American as the platonic ideal. How I jumped to that conclusion is hard to say, exactly. The visibility of Asia America on early YouTube comedy and makeup tutorials played a significant part. There was something about seeing videos of Ryan Higa and FrmHeadtoToe racking up thousands of views that made me feel seen, in my small, mostly white school of less than 500 students. My first and only YouTube comment was on a Girls' Generation music video. I remember commenting (in 2000s-era textspeak and erratic capitalization) that I wished my 11 year old classmates would just recognize how "epic" and diverse Asians were. Some brief, equally illegible reply from an Asian American user was enough to convince me that yes, my

community was there.

Having lived in the US for a couple of years, I have since witnessed the bizarre representational politics that white supremacy has created. That also includes examples of apathy, disengagement and self-interest from self-described Asian Americans, both in my daily, regular interactions, as well as on the internet writ large. The present-day label is so far distanced from its origins in the multiracial Pan-Asianism of the 1970s, solidarities with the Black Panther Party, and the "Third World" at large. We have been censused by the state into a totally useless category, with the largest disparities in wealth, educational attainment, and social mobility of all other census categories. What does Asia America refer to? It feels like a lazy, easy way to refer to more than 25 million people, while hiding the conflict and heterogeneity endemic in such a large group of people. The name Asia America no longer feels powerful for me. For myself, the label no longer engenders aspirational belonging and recognition. It seems no longer a useful way of connecting people, and more a reflection of how the state relates to groups of people, en masse, generic, and simplified.

If Asia America once reflected solidarities and similarities between people, now, I am interested in what binds AND separates us. If we are less alike than we think, what moves to empathize with one another? I don't think the answer lies in the hyphenation of two entire continents.

"What do I owe you again?" $6.99

Returning to Graeber, he writes, 'I will define communism here as any human relationship that operates on the principles of "from each according to their abilities, to each according to their needs". [...] Almost everyone follows this principle if they are collaborating on some common project [...]This is presumably also why in the immediate wake of great disasters [...] people tend to behave the same way, reverting to a rough-and-ready communism. However briefly, hierarchies and markets and the like become luxuries that no one can afford. [...] the way that strangers become sisters and brothers and human society itself seems to be reborn. [...] We are not simply talking about cooperation. [...] communism is the foundation of all human sociability. It is what makes society possible.'

I didn't want to paraphrase this mic drop, but for those with shorter attention spans like my own, Graeber talks about how care from those who can, to those who need is the prerequisite for society. It is far more efficient to act like this, and he gives some other examples to demonstrate that. When someone on the street asks you for directions, you naturally (try) to give them correct ones. What's in it for you to send someone down the wrong path? Nothing, really. So why not just be helpful? He abstracts this baseline helpfulness by looking at why insults sting. They hurt because they are unkind, and there is this unsaid expectation that social relations are ordinarily based on geniality, and so it is a choice to be an asshole. I think we forget this sentiment, that it is not just shared identity that brings people together, but a common survival instinct.

And within the specific context of the US, shared identity is somewhat borne out of the necessity to survive. As a nation founded by conquest, unfettered expansionism, and ultimately, genocide, the national project is, and has always been, about white supremacy. Only white supremacy can uphold the various systems of extraction, dehumanization and control that are

essential to the US's function. When white supremacy defines who "gets" to be free and brave, and who is disappeared at gunpoint, it is not only defiant, but a survival mechanism to name and witness the rest of us. Realizing the power of the masses, and the many things that connect us is an incredibly potent feeling. Collective effervescence, as in, that electrifying feeling of shared purpose described by Emile Durkheim, is in part, what moves us to act in unity.

Of late, I don't think that shared purpose or identity has sufficiently moved so-called Asian Americans to act outside of self-interest. The identity politic of the US is so notorious in its zero sum game, where the focus is for a seat at the table, and not why there are limited seats in the first place. Our self-preservation can act as a blinder to questioning the system at large; to extending our empathy. We forget our moral debt to one another, at large.

Identification in Disidentification $7.99

And I'd argue, we've forgotten our moral debt to one another, even within alleged communities. All this talk of the loneliness epidemic despite our technological ability to be connected reveals that our fundamental connections to one another are petering out. So, if our similarities aren't sufficient to reinforce our moral codes, could our differences?

I began with the observation that most relationships are formed based on common experience. Material conditions, while related, are different. There is a feeling of oxymoronic proximity when you realize you and your neighbors are struggling with the same slumlord, the same black mold, or the same despot, despite all your other differences. Of course, some people have the means to escape a nasty situation, but I'd argue that increasingly, most people don't. Wages have not risen in line with the cost of living, and more of us are living more precariously than we realize. That's why tenant organizing is one of the most effective ways of

activism and self-determination. You realize how it sucks for you, and how it also sucks for the person next door, and it is a bloc founded on anger and empathy. I don't doubt that it is easier to get people with similar values, histories, language, culture to agree. To care about those beyond your line of sight requires a much more complicated task of Disidentification. To acknowledge superficial differences, and recognize us all as subjects at the kangaroo court of Capitalism. To be in modern debt peonage — mostly working without a choice, to labor in exchange for living.

My debt $8.88

I want to end this exploration by turning the lens on myself. I was laid off a few years ago. Instead of endlessly applying to uninspiring jobs and crying on my couch, I decided to make better use of my time and responded to an Instagram story recruiting Chinese speakers for a food distro in a Chinese neighborhood. Twice a week, we'd give out up to a hundred free cooked meals. There was a lot going on in the world at large, and the organizers' attention and energy were stretched thin. Everything felt so precarious. I had assumed I would be one of at least a few Cantonese organizers, but the realization that there were only 3, with only one a long-term resident, was uncomfortable. And so, I recruited my friends, who I thought would add the authenticity and culturally appropriate empathy the group seemed to desperately need. Our precarity did not improve. In fact, it worsened.

There are very specific reasons for this. Even the most well-adjusted group would struggle with, for example, losing your only source of food donations. It was hard, often being the only member who could speak with the community we interacted with. But with some distance, I can dissect my own reasons for participating. I realized that it was from me, according to my abilities ... and that was about it. There was an extremely limited understanding of the needs of the community we "served", beyond

vague and sometimes even harmful assumptions. And just because my friends and I shared a language with these people, did not make me any better at understanding and relating to their needs. We didn't share any of the same lived experiences - I didn't live in the neighborhood, I didn't go to the same markets to shop, and I had never experienced food insecurity. That's not to say that I couldn't sympathize, but I wasn't part of their communities. I didn't even know how they defined who was part of their community! And the fact that I was from another city they had zero relationship with, was intended to be their advocate, their sole interlocutor — that felt absurd. I knew I wasn't solely responsible to bridge that gap of understanding, but the fact that task fell to me in the first place left a sour taste. My identity became shorthand for the "mutual" element of the entire enterprise. It wasn't just because the other organizers were white, or that they didn't live nearby — it was that we never recognized what it was we shared, and so we could never move our relationship to something that was truly mutual.

I eventually left the group. I don't condemn them at all. But I think much of modern mutual aid does not come from an understanding of our debts, at large. For myself, it was only when I became aware of my own precarity - that I was a couple of paychecks away from not being able to make rent - did I also start not only recognizing, but acting regularly and daily to address the precarity of others. When I lost my job, I felt that the world owed me some care, a safety net, some payback — it had pushed me off the conveyor belt of life, through a "decision absolutely not based on merit or performance", but I was the one left scrambling to find the means to exist. I was able to feel, properly, the debt I owed to others that kept my head about water. And not just those that directly supported me, but to those that are systematically abandoned and actively disinherited. I'm extraordinarily lucky to have multiple fallbacks, including a partner who covered my rent for almost a year, and family (with ulterior motives) who begged me to come and spend some time at home. In the context of the rest of the world, I have it easy. An editorial

comment on an earlier draft posed this question to me: "What about those who were abandoned by this system the moment they're born, before they're born?"

YOUR TOTAL IS: $38.82

I think the answer to my self-posed question is that care based on shared identity falls short. Other identifiers outside of race, such as class, gender, religion, or age might go a little further in encouraging some broader empathy. But I think that we lack the experience and habit of engaging with those we superficially share less with. We forget the origins of human sociability in maintaining positive and caring relationships with others, even with strangers. Maybe this is a bit of a circular argument, to essentially move the focus from shared identity, to intersectional identities. Asia America is no longer an effective vehicle for connection or care. Uncritical loyalty based on perceived similarities means nothing under our current harsh realities. We ought to remember our debts to one another — regardless of whether we look alike, talk alike, act alike, or not. And maybe, fully confronting what we don't share is more important than we once thought.

THANK YOU! PLEASE COME AGAIN!